

76 Approximate quantity

If specific figures are known, it can be useful to give them. However, more general terms may be needed if figures are not known, or to avoid repetition.

See also:

Singular and plural nouns 69

Numbers 74 "As... as" comparisons 96

76.1 APPROXIMATE QUANTITIES

There are certain quantifying phrases used in English when exact figures are not known, or not necessary to give.



3 out of 15 students live off campus.

In some cases, students live off campus.

"Some" is very unspecific. The only numbers it could not mean in this example are none, one, or 15.

TIP

"Minority" and "majority" are often qualified, for example "small minority" or "vast majority."

FURTHER EXAMPLES



In a minority of cases,
In a few cases,

employers provide funding for education.

A minority is less than half, but often refers to much less than half.



In most cases,
In the majority of cases,

students can contact their professors online.

"Most" and "majority" refer to more than half.



In some cases,
In a number of cases,

students can live in dorms on campus.

These unspecific references could mean a majority or minority of cases.